Chapter 5 · Story

Everyone says yes. Has everyone agreed?

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The quiet vote · c05s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What could reveal concerns before discussion?

A Have the chair announce the preferred answer.

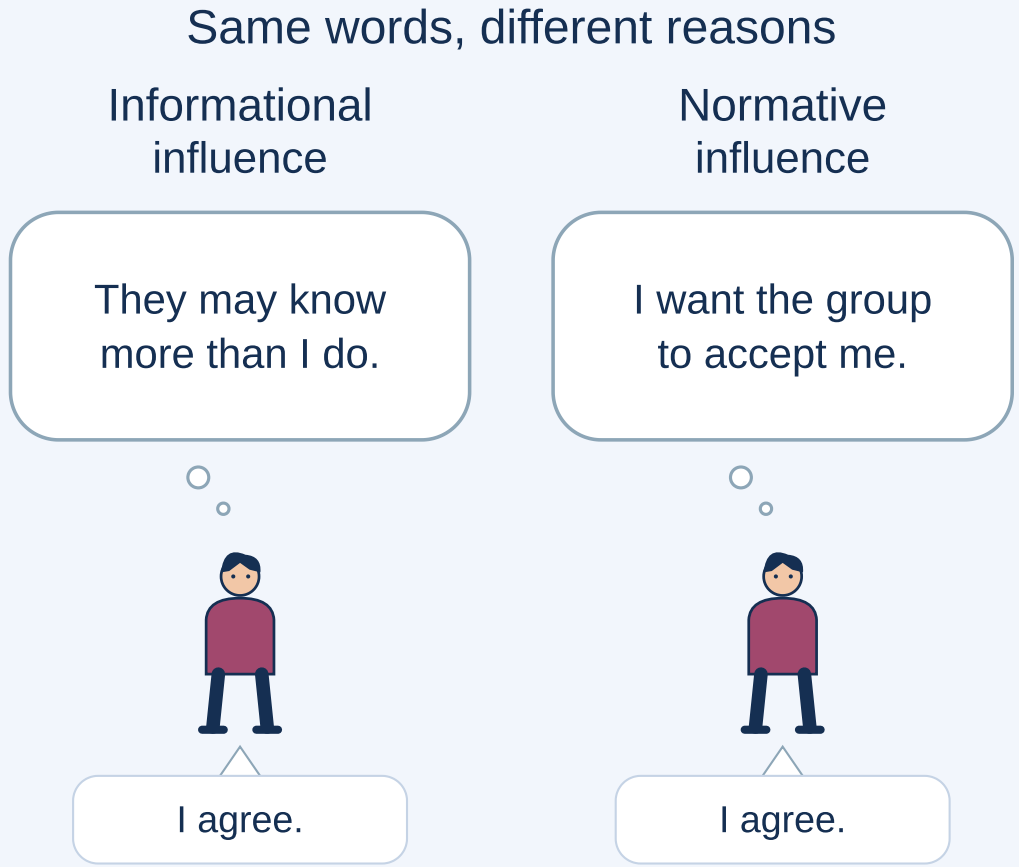
B Collect independent written judgments first.

C Ask only experienced members to speak.

Suggested answer: B. Independent written judgments let people record a view before seeing which answer has public support.

Two reasons to follow a group.

- **Informational influence**: they may know better.
- **Normative influence**: I want acceptance.
- Public agreement can differ from private belief.



The same public agreement can reflect different private reasons.

A request and an authority’s order.

- **Compliance**: responding to a request.
- **Obedience**: responding to an authority’s order.
- An authority’s request can involve both.
- The role can add pressure; resistance remains possible.

A request and an authority’s order

Compliance



Leo asks Sam: “Cover my shift?” Sam agrees to the request.

Obedience



The chair instructs: “Skip the check.” The authority role can add pressure.

An authority’s request can involve both. People can question or resist.

Authority can add pressure; it does not make resistance impossible.

Make questioning possible before work continues.

- **Notice**: a required equipment check is being bypassed.
- **Pause**: use the café’s agreed stop rule.
- **Raise**: use the agreed route for the concern.
- **Review**: clarify responsibilities before proceeding.

Make questioning practically possible

1. **A required check is bypassed**
   Notice the concern
2. **Pause the unsafe work**
   Use an agreed stop rule
3. **Raise the concern**
   Use the agreed escalation route
4. **Review before proceeding**
   Relevant training and responsibilities

An instruction does not remove accountability.

An agreed route makes a concern actionable.

What can we really conclude?

In Asch’s line-judgment studies, participants compared line lengths after hearing a group give incorrect answers. The studies examined when people would follow a majority despite the visible evidence. In Milgram’s studies, an experimenter urged participants to continue a task they believed delivered electric shocks to another person. The studies examined responses to apparent authority in a highly structured setting. Both sets of studies raise questions about methods, ethics, and how widely their findings apply. Their results concern particular conditions of influence; they are not universal obedience rates. Some participants resisted, and responses varied with the conditions. Harmful conduct is not inevitable.

Different tasks, specific pressures

Asch’s task



Compare line lengths after a majority gives incorrect answers. Some people resist.

Milgram’s task



An experimenter urges continuation. Participants believe another person receives shocks.

Methods, ethics, and conditions matter.
These are not universal obedience rates.

Task, setting, ethics, and variation limit generalization.

Try the idea somewhere new.

The chair requests bypassing a required check. Which process helps?

A Let the first confident person decide.

B Allow anonymous complaints afterward.

C Pause and use an agreed safety escalation route.

Suggested answer: C. An agreed stop-and-escalation route makes questioning possible while the safety decision still matters.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish normative and informational influence.

> Why can public agreement overstate private agreement?

1. Normative influence concerns acceptance. Informational influence treats other people’s responses as evidence.

2. Public agreement can hide private doubt when people copy early answers, suppress concerns, or assume that others have checked.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

For an agreed, low-stakes group choice, have everyone write a view before discussion. Compare the range of initial reasons with what a show of hands might have revealed.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.